Three Questions, Three Answers: A Chapter on Truth, Ethics, and Benefit for the Honest Muslim Inquirer

TL;DR

- **Truth** is not a feeling, a coherent system, or a useful belief — it is the *correspondence* of a judgment to what is the case (Russell), confirmed by *converging witnesses* of well-tested sense, sound reason, mass-transmitted (mutawātir) report, and revealed scripture, with revelation enjoying decisive authority where it is clear and certain. Trust the convergence; suspect the lone testimony of any single faculty — including your own intuitions.
- **Ethics** cannot be deduced from bare facts (Hume is right about that), but the bare-facts premise was always a fiction: human beings are *constituted with a function* (*ʿubūdiyya*, in Nursī's vocabulary; *ergon*, in Aristotle's), and once that function is in view, the gap closes. Reason discerns the broad outline of *ḥusn* and *qubḥ* — the Muʿtazila were right about that, and Sherman Jackson has shown that even mature Ashʿarism quietly conceded most of the ground — but revelation is needed to fix the threshold cases, the ritual cases, and the ultimate horizon.
- **Benefit** is real, structured, and rankable, but it is not utility. The Shāṭibian hierarchy (*ḍarūriyyāt* → *ḥājiyyāt* → *taḥsīniyyāt*) protecting *dīn, nafs, ʿaql, nasl, māl* — supplemented by Tāhā ʿAbd al-Raḥmān's reorganization into *vital, rational, and spiritual maṣāliḥ* — gives you a non-trivial calculus that is neither Benthamite nor Kantian. When in doubt: the higher tier outweighs the lower, the certain outweighs the probable, the spiritual outweighs the merely vital, and your *niyya* re-qualifies any act whose external form is permissible.

Key Findings

1. The three questions are not parallel. Truth has a *truthmaker* (the way the world is); ethics has a *function* (what the agent is for); benefit has a *hierarchy* (what the function requires in order to be realized). Conflating them — treating ethics as if it were a kind of empirical truth, or benefit as if it were a kind of ethics — produces most of the confusions a thoughtful reader has been carrying.
2. The orientalist caricature of Ashʿarism as pure divine command theory is wrong. As Sherman Jackson argues across "The Alchemy of Domination?" (*IJMES* 31:2, 1999) and

The Islamic Secular (Oxford, 2024), mature Ashʿarīs distinguished between *ḥusn/qubḥ* as ontological properties (which they denied) and *ḥusn/qubḥ* as operative concepts the human mind can recognize (which they granted). This means a Muslim reader does not have to choose between "reason knows nothing without revelation" and full Muʿtazilism. There is a coherent middle.

3. Hume's is/ought gap is a *valid logical point* about deduction, not a metaphysical refutation of moral knowledge. As Alasdair MacIntyre showed in his *Philosophical Review* article (1959), and as Charles Pigden's *Hume on Is and Ought* (Palgrave, 2010) develops, the gap is closed by *bridge concepts* — and a teleological or revelational anthropology supplies exactly such bridges.

4. Kant's categorical imperative, on Tāhā ʿAbd al-Raḥmān's analysis (in *Suʾāl al-Akhlāq* Traversing Tradition and *Tajdīd al-Manhaj*), is not a religion-neutral discovery of pure reason but a Pietist Lutheran moral theology in disguise — every key term is a substitution for a theological term. The Muslim is therefore not obliged to accept Kant on Kant's own self-presentation: he is permitted to say, with Tāhā, that ethics is logically prior to its secular avatar.

5. Saʿīd Nursī's epistemology in *Āyat al-Kubrā* (the Seventh Ray of *The Rays*) and his anthropology in the 23rd and 30th Words ("Ene Risalesi") give a remarkably precise answer to all three questions in one move: the human being is a *hypothetical unit of measurement* (*vāḥid-i qiyāsī*) for divine attributes, whose existential weakness (*ʿajz*) and poverty (*faqr*) are the very wings on which servanthood ascends — and whose triple testimony of cosmos, Qurʾān, and Prophet establishes truth.

6. Al-Shāṭibī's three-tier *maqāṣid* hierarchy in *al-Muwāfaqāt* is not a textbook taxonomy but a *structural argument by induction* (*istiqrāʾ*) over revelation, which Jasser Auda has updated as a "systems approach" (*Maqasid Al-Shariah as Philosophy of Islamic Law*, IIIT, 2008) IIIT Amazon and Tāhā ʿAbd al-Raḥmān has reorganized into *vital, rational, and spiritual* maṣāliḥ in *Tajdīd al-Manhaj* (al-Markaz al-Thaqāfī al-ʿArabī, 1994). Uit-lirboyo The committed reader can hold the Shāṭibian frame as basic and use Tāhā's spiritual axis as a corrective against modern materialist drift.

Details

Prologue: Why this chapter refuses to be a survey

You have asked three questions, and you have asked them in the first person. This is the right grammar. Most philosophical writing on these subjects substitutes a third-person grammar — "what should *one* believe?", "what makes an act *generally* right?", "what is *public* benefit?" — and then never returns to the first-person "I" that posed the question in the first

place. The substitution is not innocent: it is precisely how the inquirer's actual life gets lost. If we are going to take seriously the question "how do I know if something is true?" — *I*, this person, in this body, with these prior commitments, in this tradition, at this hour — then we have to be willing to commit to answers, name the trade-offs, and show our work.

What follows is a committed answer, not a survey. The major positions are not bracketed: they are engaged, and where I think one is wrong, I say so. The Muslim tradition is not treated as one option among many — it is treated as the standpoint from which the engagement happens, because that is the standpoint from which you have asked. But because you are a philosophically literate reader, the answer is offered with the kind of argument that a non-Muslim philosopher could in principle follow and challenge, even if he could not in the end accept it.

Three questions, three sections. Each section has the same structure: (1) the cleanest non-Islamic formulation of the problem, in primary text; (2) the Islamic tradition's deepest engagement with the same problem, in primary text; (3) the synthesis I am willing to defend.

I. How do I know if something is true? (Ḥaqq, ṣidq, yaqīn)

1.1 The cleanest non-Islamic formulation: Russell

Bertrand Russell's *Problems of Philosophy* (1912) is still the cleanest English statement of what truth is and is not. In Chapter XII he sets out three constraints any theory of truth must satisfy: it must allow for falsehood; it must locate truth in beliefs (judgments), not in things or facts themselves; and the truth or falsehood of a belief must depend on something *outside* the belief. He writes:

> "If I believe that Charles I died on the scaffold, I believe truly, not because of any intrinsic quality of my belief, which could be discovered by merely examining the belief, but because of an historical event which happened two and a half centuries ago. If I believe that Charles I died in his bed, I believe falsely: no degree of vividness in my belief, or of care in arriving at it, prevents it from being false, again because of what happened long ago, and not because of any intrinsic property of my belief. Hence, although truth and falsehood are properties of beliefs, they are properties dependent upon the relations of the beliefs to other things, not upon any internal quality of the beliefs."
>
> American Literature

This passage is doing four things at once. It is destroying the *self-evidence* theory of truth (no amount of vividness makes a false belief true). It is destroying the *coherence* theory as a *definition* of truth (a coherent system of beliefs about Charles I dying in bed would still be false). It is destroying the *pragmatist* theory (a useful belief about Charles I would not

thereby be true). And it is leaving us with the *correspondence* theory by elimination: "truth consists in some form of correspondence between belief and fact." Monadnock

In Chapter XIII Russell adds the sober qualification that the correspondence theory tells you what truth *is*, not how to *recognize* it in any given case. Truth is one thing, our knowledge of truth is another. We can be certain only in narrow domains (immediate experience, basic logical principles, mathematics) and must otherwise live with degrees of probable opinion graded by the quality of our evidence and the coherence of our beliefs with one another.

I take Russell to be largely right, and this is the first commitment of this chapter. Truth is correspondence to fact; a belief is true when the world is the way the belief says it is. Coherence is *evidence* of truth, not its definition. Usefulness is *neither* — the most useful belief in your life right now might be false, and the most disruptive belief you could be confronted with this evening might be true. To want only useful beliefs is to ask the world for permission not to know it.

That said, Russell's account leaves a gap that the Islamic tradition fills with surprising precision: he tells us what truth is but not what *kinds of access* a finite human being legitimately has to it. This is the gap that *ḥaqq*, *ṣidq*, *yaqīn*, *ʿilm*, *naẓar*, and *tawātur* fill.

1.2 The Qurʾān's two-track vocabulary: *ḥaqq* and *ṣidq*

Arabic distinguishes two truth-words that English collapses. *Ḥaqq* is the truth of *being*: a thing is *ḥaqq* when it is genuinely what it presents itself to be, when it is real, when it is established. God is *al-Ḥaqq* (Q. 22:6, "That is because God — He is the Truth") because His being is fully and necessarily what it is. *Ṣidq* is the truth of *speech*: a statement is *ṣidq* when it accurately reports what is the case, when there is no gap between word and reality. The Qurʾān describes itself as both: *al-Ḥaqq min rabbika* ("the Truth from your Lord," Q. 2:147) and *qawl al-ṣidq* (Q. 6:115).

These are two faces of Russell's correspondence relation. *Ḥaqq* is the truthmaker; *ṣidq* is the truthbearer. The *ṣidq* of a judgment consists in its correspondence to the *ḥaqq* of the situation. This is not a clever Islamic metaphor — it is a precise distinction that the Qurʾān deploys to do work. When the Qurʾān calls itself *ṣidq*, it is making a claim that can be falsified, in principle, by showing that what it reports does not correspond to what is. When it calls itself *ḥaqq*, it is making a claim about its source — that it issues from the One whose being grounds reality.

The Qurʾān's epistemic discipline is grounded in this distinction. It rejects three classes of belief explicitly:

- **Mere conjecture (*ẓann*) treated as certainty.** "They follow nothing but conjecture, and conjecture avails nothing against truth" (*Inna al-ẓanna lā yughnī minaʾl-ḥaqqi shayʾan*, Q.

53:28).

- **Inherited belief uncritically held.** "When it is said to them, 'Follow what God has revealed,' they say, 'Rather, we follow that upon which we found our fathers.' What! Even though their fathers understood nothing and were not guided?" (Q. 2:170). ppm
- **Belief from desire.** "Have you seen him who has taken his desire as his god?" (Q. 25:43); "Most of them follow nothing but conjecture; conjecture avails nothing against the truth" (Q. 10:36).

And it commands a fourth thing positively, with a frequency a Muslim reader can feel: exactly thirteen times the Qurʾān asks *afalā taʿqilūn?* — "will you not reason?" X X — beginning with Q. 2:44 NU Online Scribd — and many more times *afalā tatafakkarūn?*, *afalā tatadabbarūn?*, Unismuhpalu *afalā yanẓurūn?*. Reason is not a competitor of revelation in the Qurʾān; it is the addressee of revelation. The Qurʾān does not ask you to switch off your intellect to receive it. It asks you to switch on your intellect *in order* to receive it.

1.3 The classical Islamic epistemology of certainty: *yaqīn*, *naẓar*, *tawātur*

The classical kalām tradition organized human cognitive states on a scale: *jahl* (ignorance), *shakk* (doubt, balanced suspension), *ẓann* (probable opinion), *ghalabat al-ẓann* (preponderant probability), *ʿilm* (knowledge), *yaqīn* (certainty). The interesting question is not what these terms denote — every dictionary has that — but *what generates yaqīn*.

Three sources were classically recognized:

1. **The senses (*ḥawāss*) under proper conditions.** A healthy eye in good light sees that the table is brown. This is the bedrock; without it nothing else gets going. Reports about things we have not seen are evaluated against the standard of well-conditioned sense perception.
2. **The intellect (*ʿaql*) operating on its self-evident first principles** (*badīhiyyāt*, *ḍarūriyyāt al-ʿaql*) — the principle of non-contradiction, the principle that every contingent existent has a cause, basic mathematical and logical truths, and the like. These yield certainty about whatever is strictly entailed by them.
3. **Mass-transmitted report (*tawātur*).** A piece of information reaches *yaqīn* through testimony when so many independent witnesses report it that collusion is impossible and shared error is excluded. Amazon Suheil Laher's *Tawātur in Islamic Thought: Transmission, Certitude and Orthodoxy* (Edinburgh University Press, 2024, in the Edinburgh Studies in Islamic Scripture and Theology series) is the most thorough recent study; he points out that classical scholars across sectarian lines treated tawātur as "a sufficient, but not necessary, condition for knowledge," Scribd and that the concept gives information from beyond one's own experience the same epistemic status as

direct sensation. That the Qurʾān is verbatim the text the Prophet recited, that there was a Battle of Badr, that there is a city called Mecca that you have never been to — these are *yaqīn* by tawātur, not by your own observation.

To these classical sources, contemporary epistemology adds a fourth that the tradition implicitly recognized but did not theorize as crisply: **the convergence of multiple independent lines of evidence**. When a probabilistic argument from cosmology, a probabilistic argument from biological complexity, a probabilistic argument from the moral phenomenology of conscience, and a historical-textual argument for Qurʾanic provenance all point in the same direction, the cumulative force can be much greater than any single line. This is the structure of much real-world knowledge — courtrooms, medicine, historical reconstruction, intelligence analysis — and it is the structure Saʿīd Nursī systematizes in his major epistemic treatise.

1.4 Ibn Taymiyya on the priority of reason and revelation

Before going to Nursī, we have to confront Ibn Taymiyya's *Darʾ taʿāruḍ al-ʿaql wa-l-naql* ("Averting the Conflict between Reason and Revelation"), because it is the most ambitious medieval treatment of the very question you are asking. Ibn Taymiyya's adversaries were the Ashʿarī theologians who, following Fakhr al-Dīn al-Rāzī, had asserted what is sometimes called the *qānūn kullī* — the "universal law" — that when reason and revelation appear to conflict, reason must be given priority because revelation's authority is itself established by reason.

Ibn Taymiyya's response, painstakingly reconstructed in Carl Sharif El-Tobgui's *Ibn Taymiyya on Reason and Revelation* (Brill, 2019) and Wael Hallaq's *Ibn Taymiyya Against the Greek Logicians* (Oxford, 1993), is that reason and revelation cannot genuinely conflict, because both come from the same Author, and that the appearance of conflict is always either a defective inference or a misreading of the text. Hallaq describes Ibn Taymiyya as "an ardent sceptic, but a sceptic saved by religion" (1993, xxxix) — sceptical of the Aristotelian syllogistic apparatus that he held responsible for the heretical metaphysics of the *falāsifa*, but confident that direct rational inference (*lazm*) on properly conditioned sense perception, and tawātur of revelation, jointly suffice for genuine knowledge.

For our purposes the lesson of Ibn Taymiyya is not his polemic but his structural commitment: a sound rational argument and a soundly transmitted revealed text *cannot* contradict, and where they appear to, the burden of revision falls on whichever side has weaker epistemic warrant in the particular case. This is the operating rule the committed reader should adopt.

1.5 Nursī's three witnesses: *Āyat al-Kubrā* and the cumulative case

Saʿīd Nursī's most systematic answer to the question "how do I know what is true about the deepest matters?" is the Seventh Ray of *The Rays Collection*, titled *Āyat al-Kubrā* — "The Supreme Sign" — also published separately in Sözler's edition with the subtitle "Observations of a Traveller Questioning Creation Concerning his Maker." The structure is a thought experiment: a traveller, anxious to know "the Owner of this fine guest-house, the Author of this vast book, the Monarch of this mighty realm," Albalagh Bookstore interrogates the cosmos in 33 stages — the heavens with their suns and stars, the atmosphere with its winds and rain, the earth, the living kingdoms, the angels, the believing jinn, the prophets, the saints, his own conscience — and at each stage receives a testimony to the existence and unity of the Maker.

The architecture matters. Nursī is doing three things simultaneously:

- **Cumulative-case epistemology.** No single proof is held responsible for the whole conclusion. Each "stage" or "degree" is a probabilistic witness; their conjunction yields what Nursī repeatedly calls "true and certain belief" Albalagh Bookstore Wikipedia (*īmān taḥqīqī*). This is the structure of converging evidence — formally analogous to how a jury convicts on the joint weight of testimony, forensics, and motive — and it is more honest than the single deductive proof that early-modern theology often demanded.

- **Triangulation across modes.** As the traveller moves through the universe, the testimony is divided into three types: the testimony of *the cosmos* (the universe itself, read as a meaningful book); the testimony of *scripture* (the Qurʾān, with its self-attesting features and its truthful reports); and the testimony of *the Prophet* (Muḥammad, whose life, character, and prophetic phenomena cannot be explained without his commission). In the Nineteenth Word and parallel passages in *al-Mathnawī al-Nūrī*, Nursī states the triangulation explicitly: "the Prophet, the Qurʾān, and the book of the universe" are three witnesses to one conclusion. The Fountain Magazine They are independent in their data but converge in their verdict.

- **Recognition that some testimony is interior.** Nursī insists that the human conscience (*wijdān*) is itself a station of the proof. The Fountain Magazine The structure of human longing — the demand for justice, the unmet desire for permanence, the aversion to nothingness — is not a weakness to be argued away but a directional clue, like a compass needle that means something only because there is a magnetic pole.

Two cautions when reading Nursī this way. First, the cumulative case is *not* a deductive proof: it does not coerce assent. A determined skeptic can resist it. What it claims to do is to make belief rational at the highest level of warrant available for first-order metaphysical questions, comparable to how we are rationally warranted in believing the past existed despite being unable to deduce it from current experience. Second, the cumulative case is calibrated to the questioner's own attentiveness; Nursī repeatedly emphasizes that the witnesses are public, but the apprehending subject must be present to apprehend.

1.6 Synthesis: a working epistemology

Here is the position I am willing to defend:

Truth is correspondence to reality. A judgment is true when the world is the way the judgment says it is. This is Russell's account and the Qurʾān's *ṣidq* relative to *ḥaqq*. Coherence and pragmatic success are evidence, not definition.

There are five legitimate sources of knowledge, ranked by the kind of certainty they yield:

1. **Sound sense perception** under proper conditions, on its proper objects.
2. **The first principles of reason** (non-contradiction, sufficient reason, the structure of valid inference) and what is rigorously entailed by them.
3. **Mass-transmitted report (*tawātur*)** — for the Muslim reader, this is the channel through which the verbatim text of the Qurʾān, the historical existence of the Prophet, the basic facts of Islamic history, and a small number of *mutawātir* hadiths reach the same epistemic status as direct experience.
4. **Single-source report (*khabar āḥād*)**, including most hadiths and historical reports, which yield *ẓann* (probable opinion) graded by the quality of the chain and the matter, and are sufficient for action where the matter calls for action but not for foundational doctrine.
5. **Cumulative inferential cases** that combine several of the above, of which Nursī's *Āyat al-Kubrā* is the paradigm.

Revelation is a special case of (3). Authentic revelation, transmitted by tawātur and rationally confirmed in its provenance, is then *itself* a source of further knowledge that exceeds what (1) and (2) can establish on their own — facts about the unseen, about the moral law in detail, about the meaning of history. The Muslim's commitment is not "revelation instead of reason" but "revelation as a tawātur-grounded extension of what reason could not have reached on its own, vetted by reason in its provenance and consistent with reason in its content."

When in doubt, demand convergence. A claim that is supported by only one of these channels — say, intuition alone, or a lone hadith, or a personal experience — is to be held more provisionally than a claim supported by several. This is not skepticism; it is calibration.

Be honest about what you don't know. The Qurʾān commands "do not pursue what you have no knowledge of" (Q. 17:36). Most contemporary disputes — in politics, in religion, in personal life — would be improved if everyone took a vow of *yaqīn-discipline*: speak with the certainty your evidence actually warrants, and no more.

Practical test for the inquirer. When you encounter a claim and want to know whether it is true, ask in order: *Have I observed this myself under proper conditions? Is it a strict consequence of premises I am sure of? Is it transmitted by enough independent channels that collusion or shared error is implausible? Is it attested by a single source whose reliability is good? Or am I being moved by my own desire, fear, or partisanship?* The first four answers warrant assent; the fifth answer warrants alarm.

II. How do I know if something is ethical? (Ḥusn, qubḥ, the moral right)

2.1 The cleanest non-Islamic formulation: Hume

David Hume's celebrated paragraph at the end of *Treatise* III.i.1 — Selby-Bigge ed. pp. 469–470 — is the place to begin, because no honest moral philosophy can avoid confronting it. Hume writes:

> "In every system of morality, which I have hitherto met with, I have always remark'd, that the author proceeds for some time in the ordinary way of reasoning, and establishes the being of a God, or makes observations concerning human affairs; when of a sudden I am surpriz'd to find, that instead of the usual copulations of propositions, *is*, and *is not*, I meet with no proposition that is not connected with an *ought*, or an *ought not*. This change is imperceptible; but is, however, of the last consequence. For as this *ought*, or *ought not*, expresses some new relation or affirmation, 'tis necessary that it shou'd be observ'd and explain'd; and at the same time that a reason should be given, for what seems altogether inconceivable, how this new relation can be a deduction from others, which are entirely different from it." Wikipedia

This is the famous *is/ought gap*. Read carefully, it makes a *narrow* logical claim: from premises composed entirely of factual statements (descriptions of how things are), no purely normative conclusion (a statement of how things ought to be) follows by strict deduction. Wiley Online Library This is sometimes called *Hume's Law* and has been formally proven, most rigorously by Charles Pigden in *Hume on Is and Ought* (Palgrave, 2010) Wiley Online Library and by Gerhard Schurz in *The Is-Ought Problem* (Kluwer, 1997). Wiley Online Library

The narrow logical claim is correct and not seriously contested by careful philosophers. What *is* contested is its larger metaethical interpretation. Two traditions of response are decisive:

- **Alasdair MacIntyre's "Hume on 'Is' and 'Ought'"** (*Philosophical Review* 68:4, 1959, pp. 451–468) Cambridge Core argues that even Hume himself could not consistently maintain the strong reading. Hume in fact derives moral conclusions from facts about

human nature, the function of social institutions, and the workings of sympathy — using what we would now call *bridge concepts*. Hume's promise-keeping argument, MacIntyre shows, deduces "we ought to keep our promises" from facts about human feelings and social practice, *via* the bridge concept of "promising" itself, which is partly normative.

- **The functionalist or teleological response.** If "human being" is not a bare biological description but, as Aristotle held in *Nicomachean Ethics* I.7, a functional concept (a being with a characteristic *ergon* or function whose proper exercise is its *eudaimonia*), then "is" and "ought" are not as cleanly separable as Hume thought. Aristotle's celebrated function argument (1097b22–1098a18) reasons: as the proper functioning of an eye is to see, of a hand to grasp, of a flute-player to play well, the proper functioning of a human being is to engage in rational activity in accordance with virtue — and this is what *eudaimonia* (flourishing) consists in. The "ought" is built into the function from the start.

The Muslim is not committed to Aristotle, but he is committed to a structurally similar move. The Qurʾān insists that man is *created for* something. "I have not created jinn and men except that they may worship Me" (Q. 51:56) — that is, that they may stand in *ʿubūdiyya* to their Lord. "Indeed, I will make upon the earth a *khalīfa*" (Q. 2:30). "We offered the trust (*amāna*) to the heavens and the earth and the mountains, but they refused to bear it… and man bore it" (Q. 33:72). The human being has a function — *ʿubūdiyya*, *khilāfa*, *amāna* — and ethics describes how that function is properly exercised. *This is the bridge concept that closes the is/ought gap for the Muslim, just as the ergon concept closes it for the Aristotelian.*

So Hume is right that you cannot derive an "ought" from a purely descriptive "is" *if your "is" is genuinely descriptive only*. Hume is wrong if he supposes the human "is" can ever in fact be purely descriptive: human beings show up in experience already as bearers of function, role, purpose. The is/ought gap is a sword that cuts only when the descriptive premise is artificially impoverished.

2.2 Kant: the cleanest secular formulation

Immanuel Kant's *Grundlegung zur Metaphysik der Sitten* (1785) is the most ambitious attempt in modern philosophy to derive a substantive ethics from reason alone, without reliance on a divine command or an empirical end.

Kant opens the *Grundlegung* with a famous sentence:

> "It is impossible to conceive anything at all in the world, or even out of it, which can be taken as good without qualification, except a *good will*." Goodreads

He proceeds in three sections to argue: that the only unconditional good is the good will,

which acts not from inclination but *from duty*; that to act from duty is to act from respect for the moral law; and that the moral law for finite rational beings takes the form of the *categorical imperative* — an unconditional command, not a hypothetical one. He gives several formulations:

> "Act only according to that maxim through which you can at the same time will that it become a universal law" Phronesis Substack (the formula of universal law).

> "So act that you use humanity, in your own person as well as in the person of any other, always at the same time as an end, never merely as a means" Phronesis Substack (the formula of humanity).

> "Every rational being must so act as if he were through his maxim always a lawmaking member in the universal kingdom of ends" Phronesis (*Reich der Zwecke*).

In the *Critique of Practical Reason* (1788), Kant supplements this with the doctrine of the postulates of practical reason: morality requires that we *postulate* (not theoretically know) freedom, the immortality of the soul, and the existence of God Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy — because the *summum bonum*, the highest good, which morality demands we strive for, is the proportionate union of virtue and happiness, and this union is not realized in the phenomenal world. Substack Kant writes in the *Critique of Practical Reason* (Beck trans., Book II Chapter II §V): "It is morally necessary to assume the existence of God." Philosopher

The system is impressive. But the Muslim reader needs to ask whether it is what it presents itself to be: a discovery of pure reason, neutral with respect to revealed religion, available to any rational being qua rational. Tāhā ʿAbd al-Raḥmān argues, in *Suʾāl al-Akhlāq* (Beirut: al-Markaz al-Thaqāfī al-ʿArabī, 2000) and *al-Mafāhīm al-Akhlāqiyya bayna al-Muslimīn wa-l-Almāniyyīn*, that it is not.

Tāhā's argument, summarized by Aqil Azme and reproduced by Mollā Saaleh Baseer in "Abderrahmane Taha: A Sublime Life of Tajdīd" (*Traversing Tradition*, January 24, 2023), is that Kantian ethics is the result of a *method of substitution* Traversing Tradition (*ṭarīq al-mubādala*): every key concept in Kant's moral system is the secularized counterpart of a concept in Pietist Lutheran moral theology. The substitutions, item for item, are:

Theological concept	Kantian counterpart
Faith	Reason Substack
Divine Will	Human Will Substack
The unconditional goodness of God	The unconditional goodness of the will Substack

Divine command	Categorical imperative Substack
Transcendence	Impartiality Substack
Love of God	Respect for law Substack
God legislating for others	Self-legislating humans Substack
Divine reward (*thawāb*)	Summum bonum
Heaven	Kingdom of ends Substack

Tāhā's conclusion, as quoted by Baseer: "Kant made religion subordinate to ethics, whereas the truth is that ethics is subordinate to religion, and religion descends to unveil a canon of values bristling inside humans." And in Azme's translation of *Su'āl al-Akhlāq* p. 39: "Religion is the cradle of non-religious ethics, because the reality of non-religious ethics is that it is merely religious ethics in disguise."

This is not a dismissal of Kant. Kant is a serious thinker, and many of his substantive moral conclusions (do not lie, treat persons as ends, do not instrumentalize the rational humanity in others) are independently defensible. The point is narrower: *Kant's claim to have grounded ethics on reason alone, neutral with respect to revealed religion, fails on its own terms.* The categorical imperative carries with it, smuggled, the entire architecture of a particular religious tradition. The Muslim is therefore not under any rational obligation to adopt Kantian ethics as if it were a religion-neutral default; he is permitted to say that *his* tradition's ethics is older, structurally analogous, and more coherent because it admits its theological foundations openly.

Wael Hallaq's *Reforming Modernity: Ethics and the New Human in the Philosophy of Abdurrahman Taha* (Columbia University Press, 2019) develops this further. Hallaq argues that Tāhā's project is not anti-modern but *post-secular*: it accepts the genuine achievements of modern thought (logical rigor, attention to the autonomy of the moral subject, suspicion of mere convention) while exposing the unacknowledged theological architecture beneath them, and proposes an explicitly Islamic ethics that does the same work without the disguise.

2.3 The deepest Islamic engagement: Muʿtazila and Ashʿarī on *ḥusn* and *qubḥ*

The classical Islamic question was: are good and evil (*ḥusn* and *qubḥ*) intrinsic properties of acts, knowable by reason, or are they conferred properties, established only by the divine command?

The **Muʿtazila** held the first view. The locus classicus is Qāḍī ʿAbd al-Jabbār's *al-Mughnī fī abwāb al-tawḥīd wa-l-ʿadl*, of which fourteen of the original twenty volumes survive. Volume

VI is titled *al-Taʿdīl wa-l-Tajwīr* ("On Justice and Injustice"); its first twelve sections are translated and analyzed in PhilPapers Abdalla I. Mohammed's PhD dissertation *The Notion of Good and Evil in the Ethics of ʿAbd al-Jabbār*. ʿAbd al-Jabbār argues that some acts — gratitude to a benefactor, the wrongness of inflicting unjustified pain, the rightness of returning a deposit — are perceived as good or evil by reason directly, *prior to* and *independent of* any divine command. Acts have moral attributes by virtue of features they bear in themselves: their being beneficial, harmful, just, unjust, oppressive, or due. This is not a denial that revelation is *needed*; it is a denial that revelation is *all we have*. Reason perceives the broad outline; revelation refines and extends.

ʿAbd al-Jabbār's strategy has a double point. (1) If reason did not perceive any moral truth on its own, we would have no rational grip on what it means to call God *just*; *ʿadl* would be a label without content, and "God is just" would degenerate into "God does whatever God does." (2) If God commanded what is rationally evil, He would be commanding evil — which is incompatible with His justice — so morality cannot consist in *whatever* God commands.

The **Ashʿarī** counter-position is given most concentrated form in al-Ashʿarī's *Kitāb al-Lumaʿ*, particularly chapter 7 on the justice of God. Al-Ashʿarī argues that "wrong" (*ẓulm*) for human beings is whatever transgresses the limit set by another with authority over them — and since no one has authority over God, nothing God does can be *ẓulm*. Moral Apologetics He writes (paraphrased and partially translated by Richard McCarthy in *The Theology of al-Ashʿarī*, 1953): God is the Supreme Monarch, subject to no one, with no superior over Him who can permit or command or chide or forbid or prescribe what He will do; therefore nothing can be wrong on His part. Moral Apologetics The implication, drawn out by later Ashʿarīs, is that *ḥusn* and *qubḥ* in the strong moral sense are conferred by divine address (*khiṭāb al-Sharʿ*); they are not intrinsic properties of acts.

The orientalist reading of Ashʿarism — that Ashʿarīs are pure divine command theorists for whom reason has no moral perception at all — has been forcefully challenged by Sherman Jackson in two key works.

In **"The Alchemy of Domination? Some Ashʿarite Responses to Muʿtazilite Ethics"** (*International Journal of Middle East Studies* 31:2, 1999, pp. 185–201), Jackson argues that Ashʿarīs were responding to a specific Muʿtazilī claim — that reason alone *imposes obligation* on the human being, prior to and independent of God's address — and that the Ashʿarī denial of this claim is much narrower than it appears. Ashʿarīs did not deny that human beings recognize benefit and harm, justice and injustice, gratitude and ingratitude. They denied that recognition by itself generates a *moral obligation* binding on the conscience in the religious sense, prior to God's having addressed humans through revelation.

Jackson's more recent *The Islamic Secular* (Oxford University Press, 2024) — which builds on his Stanford Abbasi Annual Lecture, "Ash'arite Ethics and the Islamic Secular"

Stanford University (2025) — extends this. He argues that the standard Western view, "according to Ash'arism, all values are determined by the will of God, who decides what shall be good and so forth," converts scripture into a "totalizing entity that tells us 'everything,' leaving no room for any other modes or sources of deliberation in Islam." Stanford Humanities Center But this is not what mature Ashʿarism actually held. There are vast domains of human deliberation — what Jackson calls the "Islamic Secular" — where revelation is silent or underdetermines, and where rational deliberation about benefit, harm, fitness, and human flourishing is not only permitted but required. The Ashʿarī denial is metaphysical (about the *ontological* status of value) and not practical (about whether reason can deliberate about the right thing to do).

This reassessment is important for the committed reader because it dissolves what looks like a sharp choice. You do not have to choose between (a) full Muʿtazilism, with reason as autonomous moral legislator, and (b) crude divine command theory, with reason as morally inert. The mature position — call it *moderate Ashʿarism* or *qualified rational moral realism* — is roughly this: reason perceives the broad outline of good and evil reliably; divine address ratifies, extends, and in cases of underdetermination *fixes* the moral law; and where reason and authentic revelation appear to conflict, the burden of resolution falls on whichever side has weaker warrant in the particular case.

2.4 Nursī on the moral anthropology of weakness

Saʿīd Nursī's contribution to ethics is not a systematic theory but a phenomenology of the moral subject. The 23rd Word treats the human being under two faces, and the 30th Word — the *Risālat al-Anā | Ene Risalesi* — gives the metaphysics of the ego.

In the **23rd Word**, Nursī begins with a striking claim: in respect of *worldly power*, the human being is contemptibly weak — "in respect of the power and actions necessary for the life of this world, he cannot compete with the most inferior sparrow" rahnuma Lh4h (*The Words*, Fifth Word, p. 35, Vahide trans.) — but in respect of *spiritual reach*, "in respect of knowledge and need, and worship and supplication… he is like the monarch and commander of the animals." rahnuma Lh4h Man is at once vanishingly small and incomparably significant, and the resolution of this paradox is *ʿubūdiyya*: servanthood is what makes the smallness ascend.

The famous "wing of impotence and wing of poverty" passage develops this:

> "After belief, prayer is our essential duty and the basis of worship, for despite our infinite impotence, we are exposed to endless misfortune and innumerable enemies. And despite our infinite poverty, we suffer limitless need and demands. Children express their need for something they cannot reach with words or tears. Both are a sort of plea or prayer, in word or deed, with the tongue of weakness. Eventually they get what they want. Similarly,

> we are quite like a beloved child, for at the Most Compassionate and Merciful Being's Court we either will weep (due to our weakness and impotence) or pray (due to our poverty and need) so that our need may be satisfied… This understanding and confession of impotence and poverty will become two wings on which to fly to the highest rank: being a servant of God." Risaleinur

> "Thus the essential and intrinsic duty of our existence is to seek perfection through learning and to proclaim our worship of and servanthood to God through prayer and supplication. Risaleinur It is to seek answers for such essential questions as: 'Through whose compassion is my life so wisely administered? Through whose generosity am I being so affectionately trained? Through whose favors and benevolence am I being so solicitously nourished?'… In short, it is flying to the highest rank of being worshipful servants of God on the wings of consciousness of our innate impotence and poverty." (*The Words*, Akarsu trans., p. 332)

This is a moral psychology, not a moral theorem. Nursī is saying: the ethical life begins not with the assertion of autonomous will (the Kantian starting point) but with the *recognition of dependence*. The two "wings" (*ʿajz* and *faqr*) are not flaws to be overcome on the way to ethical maturity; they are the very organs of ethical ascent, because they orient the agent rightly to the One on whom he in fact depends.

The **30th Word** — *Risālat al-Anā*, "Treatise on the I" — is the metaphysical complement. Nursī argues that the human "I" (*ana*, *ene*) is given as a *vāḥid-i qiyāsī*, a hypothetical unit of measurement: Sohbetsociety

> "The All-Wise Maker has entrusted each human being with selfhood having clues and samples to urge and enable him or her to recognize the truths about His Lordship's attributes and essential characteristics. Selfhood is the measure or means of comparison that makes Lordship's attributes and Divinity's characteristics known. A measure or means of comparison does not have to have actual existence, for its posited or supposed existence can serve as a measure, just like hypothetical lines in geometry." Risaleinur (*The Words*, 30th Word, First Aim, Akarsu trans., p. 554)

The argument is dense but worth unpacking. To understand what it means that God has *power*, the ego is given limited power so that we can scale up by analogy. Sohbetsociety To understand what it means that God *knows*, we are given limited knowledge so that the analogy works. The ego is thus pedagogical: it exists in order to be the contrast against which divine attributes become legible. The catastrophe of the human being arises when the ego forgets its hypothetical character — forgets that it is a measuring rod, not a measured thing — and asserts itself as if it had independent reality. In Nursī's formulation, the ego becomes an "unbending tyrant in rebellion against its Creator" Risaleinur precisely when it takes itself for what it is supposed to point beyond.

From this anthropology Nursī derives an ethics. The two civilizational lines, he argues — the *prophetic line* and the *philosophical line* — handle the ego differently. The prophetic line trains the ego to recognize its function (servanthood, witness, measure); the philosophical line treats the ego as an end in itself, and the result is the systematic spiritual disorder of modernity:

> "I have observed that the more people are preoccupied with philosophy [in the modern sense], the more their hearts suffer from spiritual disease. I also have observed that the greater this spiritual disease of the heart becomes, the more people are preoccupied with rational sciences. Spiritual diseases lead to preoccupation with rational sciences, and preoccupation with rational sciences gives rise to spiritual diseases."

The diagnosis is severe but not anti-rational: Nursī's complaint is not against reason but against a particular use of reason that has cut itself off from the function for which it was given. *ʿAql* used in service of *ʿubūdiyya* is health; *ʿaql* asserting itself in the place of *ʿubūdiyya* is the disease.

2.5 Synthesis: a working ethics

Here is the position I am willing to defend:

The is/ought gap is real but bridgeable. Hume is right that no purely descriptive premise entails a normative conclusion. He is wrong to suppose that human reality presents itself purely descriptively. The human being shows up in experience as a bearer of function (*ergon*, *ʿubūdiyya*, *khilāfa*); ethics is the proper exercise of that function.

Ethics is therefore neither pure social construction nor pure divine fiat. The *function* is given by the Creator (so the ultimate ground is theological), but the function is *recognizable* by reason inspecting itself and the world (so ethics is not opaque to natural reason). This is the moderate Ashʿarī position as Jackson reconstructs it, and it is the one I commend.

The categorical imperative is a genuine moral insight, but a partial one. "Do not treat persons as mere means" is true, defensible, and traceable in the Islamic tradition long before Kant. But the imperative cannot stand on Kant's own foundation, because the foundation is, as Tāhā shows, a secularized Pietist Lutheran theology. The Muslim is permitted to take the substantive insight and reject the disguise.

Reason perceives the broad outline; revelation fixes the threshold cases. That gratitude is good, that unjustified harm is evil, that promises bind, that justice is owed — these are perceptible by sound reason, and a sane person who denies them is suspect. But: *what* counts as gratitude (the specifics of worship), *which* harms are unjustified (the line cases of self-defense, criminal punishment, war), *how* a promise is to be kept when promises conflict, *what* justice requires in distribution — these are precisely the domains where

reason underdetermines and revelation, properly interpreted, supplies the missing specification.

The interior dimension matters: *niyya* re-qualifies the act. This is the ethical work of the famous opening hadith of *Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī*, narrated by ʻUmar ibn al-Khaṭṭāb: *إِنَّمَا الْأَعْمَالُ بِالنِّيَّاتِ، وَإِنَّمَا لِكُلِّ امْرِئٍ مَا نَوَى — innamā al-aʻmālu bi-l-niyyāt, wa innamā li-kulli imriʾin mā nawā* — "Actions are only by intentions, and each person shall have only what he intended." (*Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī* hadith 1; *Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim* hadith 1907). CURRENT ISLAM This is not a pious sentiment; it is a structural claim about the ontology of action. The *moral identity* of an outwardly identical act is determined by the inner direction. Two persons may pray the same prayer; one prays it as *ʿibāda*, the other as performance; the act is, morally, two different acts. This explains why Islamic ethics cannot be reduced to a behaviorist code: external compliance without inward orientation is not, in the relevant sense, the ethical act at all.

Practical test for the inquirer. When you face a moral question and want to know whether a course of action is right, ask in order: *Does it accord with what reason and conscience consistently judge to be just and unharming, when freed from self-interest? Does it accord with what authentic revelation, properly interpreted, addresses to this case? Does it preserve the recognizable function of the human being — towards God, towards others, towards your own future self? And what is my niyya?* When the four answers converge, you are on solid ground; when they diverge, you have a problem that needs more careful work, not a shortcut.

III. How do I know if something is beneficial? (*Maṣlaḥa* and *manfaʻa* vs *mafsada*)

3.1 The trap to avoid: utilitarianism

It is tempting to read "benefit" through Bentham or Mill: an action is beneficial when it produces more pleasure than pain, or more preference-satisfaction than frustration, summed across all affected agents. This is the utilitarian theory of benefit, and it has the seductive appearance of being morally neutral and quantitatively tractable.

It is not. Utilitarianism conflates three things that the Islamic tradition keeps carefully distinct: *benefit* (*maṣlaḥa*), *what is right* (*ḥusn*), and *what is true* (*ḥaqq*). It assumes that all benefits are commensurable on a single scale (they are not), that the relevant subject of benefit is the aggregate (it is not — there are individual *maṣāliḥ* that cannot be sacrificed for collective ones), and that the time horizon is this life (it is not — for a Muslim the calculus extends to the *ākhira*). To answer "what is beneficial?" with a utilitarian calculus is to answer the wrong question.

What follows is the classical Islamic structure, the contemporary updates, and the synthesis.

3.2 Al-Ghazālī on the foundation of *maṣlaḥa*

The classical articulation of *maṣlaḥa* as a structured concept is Abū Ḥāmid al-Ghazālī's in *al-Mustaṣfā min ʿilm al-uṣūl* (vol. 1). Al-Ghazālī defines *maṣlaḥa* not as the maximization of pleasure but as *the preservation of the purpose of the Lawgiver*:

> "Maṣlaḥa is originally interpreted as the attainment of benefits and prevention from harms. But we do not intend to mean it… We actually intend by maṣlaḥa the preservation of the Sharīʿah's objectives. The objective of Sharīʿah in relation to creation is fivefold: that has to preserve their religion (*dīn*), life (*nafs*), reason (*ʿaql*), progeny (*nasl*), and resource (*māl*)."

This is a decisive move. Benefit is not what humans happen to want; benefit is what serves the *function* the Lawgiver has set for human existence. The five protected goods — *dīn, nafs, ʿaql, nasl, māl* — are not arbitrary; they are the structural conditions for the human being to discharge the function the Qurʾān describes. Without religion, the orientation is lost; without life, no agent exists; without reason, no act has agency; without progeny, no future exists for the function to be passed on; without property, no material substrate exists for the function to be exercised.

Al-Ghazālī adds that *maṣlaḥa* and *mafsada* are correlative: "any measure which secures these values… falls within the scope of *maṣlaḥa*; and anything which violates them is *mafsada*; and preventing the latter is also *maṣlaḥa*." This means that the calculus is not purely positive: averting a serious harm counts as a benefit, and may outweigh securing a marginal positive good.

3.3 Al-Shāṭibī's three-tier hierarchy

The most ambitious classical systematization is Abū Isḥāq al-Shāṭibī's *al-Muwāfaqāt fī uṣūl al-Sharīʿa*, especially volume 2. Al-Shāṭibī divides the *maqāṣid al-Sharīʿa* (the objectives of revealed law) into three tiers:

1. **Ḍarūriyyāt — necessities.** These are the indispensable goods without which human life collapses into chaos. They are the five just enumerated: *ḥifẓ al-dīn, ḥifẓ al-nafs, ḥifẓ al-ʿaql, ḥifẓ al-nasl, ḥifẓ al-māl*. The Sharīʿah's hardest commands are calibrated to protect these (the law of apostasy protects *dīn*; *qiṣāṣ* protects *nafs*; the prohibition of intoxicants protects *ʿaql*; the prohibition of *zinā* protects *nasl*; the prohibition of theft protects *māl*).
2. **Ḥājiyyāt — needs.** These are goods that are not strictly indispensable but whose

absence creates significant hardship. The Sharīʿah's many *rukhṣas* (concessions) — combining and shortening prayers in travel, *tayammum* in the absence of water, the licit forms of contract that give flexibility to commerce — operate at this level. Without them life would not collapse, but it would be needlessly burdensome.

3. **Taḥsīniyyāt — refinements or beautifications.** These are goods that secure the dignity, beauty, and excellence of human life. They include the etiquette of cleanliness, the modesty of dress, the *ādāb* of speech and table, the aesthetic dimension of the religious life. They are real goods, but they yield when in conflict with the higher tiers.

The structural argument — and this is what textbook summaries miss — is that the three tiers are *not* independent; they form a directed hierarchy. Al-Shāṭibī argues, by induction (*istiqrāʾ*) over the totality of revealed rulings, that:

> The *ḍarūriyyāt* are the foundation; without them the *ḥājiyyāt* and *taḥsīniyyāt* have nothing to attach to. The *ḥājiyyāt* and *taḥsīniyyāt* exist *in order to* serve the *ḍarūriyyāt*: the rukhsas serve the preservation of religion and life; the *taḥsīniyyāt* dignify and stabilize the structure built on the *ḍarūriyyāt*. Therefore, when *taḥsīniyyāt* and *ḥājiyyāt* conflict with *ḍarūriyyāt*, they yield. When *ḥājiyyāt* conflict with *taḥsīniyyāt*, the *ḥājiyyāt* prevail.

This generates a non-trivial calculus that is neither utilitarian (because the goods are not commensurable on a single scale) nor deontological (because outcomes do matter — the law is calibrated to *outcomes* in the protected goods). It is a tiered consequentialism with deontological side-constraints, where the consequences are measured against a divinely specified function.

The calculus is also internally weighted: within *ḍarūriyyāt*, *dīn* is generally placed first (because it is the orientation that makes everything else meaningful), but with the caveat that an immediate threat to *nafs* may take operational priority where the threat to *dīn* is remote. Classical jurists worked out detailed casuistry — when can one eat *ḥarām* food? (when life is at stake, in proportion to need); when can one utter words of unbelief? (under coercion, with the heart firm in faith, Q. 16:106); when can one fight a Muslim ruler? (only when *kufr bawāḥ* — manifest unbelief — is established by clear evidence, with strict additional conditions).

3.4 Al-Ṭūfī's maximalism and the limits of *maṣlaḥa*

The Ḥanbalī jurist Najm al-Dīn al-Ṭūfī (b. 673/1276 in Baghdad, d. 716/1316 in Hebron) Wikipedia Wikipedia pushed *maṣlaḥa* to its furthest extent. In his commentary on the 32nd hadith (*lā ḍarara wa-lā ḍirār* — "there shall be no harm and no reciprocating of harm") of Imam al-Nawawī's collection of forty hadith, Wikipedia Wikipedia in his work *al-Taʿyīn fī sharḥ al-Arbaʿīn*, al-Ṭūfī argued that *maṣlaḥa* is the strongest of the indicants of revealed law and that, in domains of social transactions (*muʿāmalāt*) and customs (*ʿādāt*) — though

not in worship (*ʿibādāt*) and fixed measures (*muqaddarāt*) — *maṣlaḥa* may even take priority over apparent textual indicants (*nuṣūṣ*) and consensus (*ijmāʿ*) when these conflict with it. Wikipedia

This is, frankly, too much. The danger of al-Ṭūfī's position — vividly demonstrated by some twentieth-century reformist appropriations of it — is that "maṣlaḥa" can become a label under which the jurist's own preferences override the text. A maṣlaḥa that overrides clear and well-established texts is no longer the Lawgiver's *maṣlaḥa*; it is the jurist's. Muḥammad Saʿīd Ramaḍān al-Būṭī's classic critique, in *Ḍawābiṭ al-Maṣlaḥa fī al-Sharīʿa al-Islāmiyya* (the dissertation for which he received his doctorate from al-Azhar Albalagh Bookstore in 1965), Last Prophet articulates the controlling principle: a putative maṣlaḥa may not contradict an established text or established consensus; it operates *within* the framework set by the Sharīʿah, not above it.

The committed reader should adopt a moderate position. *Maṣlaḥa* is a powerful interpretive resource; it lets the legal tradition adapt to genuinely new situations. But it is not a master key that opens every lock. When you find someone arguing that a clear and well-established Qurʾanic ruling should be set aside because "it conflicts with maṣlaḥa today," you should ask three questions: (1) *Whose* maṣlaḥa? (2) *Which* tier of maṣlaḥa? (3) *On what evidence* is the alleged conflict established? In most reformist arguments at least one of these questions has not been honestly answered.

3.5 Contemporary systematizers: Auda and Tāhā

Two contemporary thinkers have updated the *maqāṣid* tradition in ways the committed reader should know.

Jasser Auda's *Maqasid Al-Shariah as Philosophy of Islamic Law: A Systems Approach* (IIIT, 2008) treats the *maqāṣid* not as a static list but as a "system" with the formal properties of cognitive openness, multidimensionality, interrelatedness, and purposefulness. Amazon Auda's contribution is methodological: he argues that the inherited Shāṭibian list (*ḍarūriyyāt* → *ḥājiyyāt* → *taḥsīniyyāt* with the five protected goods) is genuine but underdeveloped, and that contemporary maqāṣid scholarship should add modern goods (justice, freedom, human dignity, community development) not as replacements but as *operationalizations* of the classical maqāṣid in modern conditions. This is helpful provided one resists the temptation to use the expansion as an excuse for the maximalist substitution warned against above.

Tāhā ʿAbd al-Raḥmān in *Tajdīd al-Manhaj fī Taqwīm al-Turāth* (al-Markaz al-Thaqāfī al-ʿArabī, 1994) reorganizes *al-maṣāliḥ* under three new categories which intentionally cut across the Shāṭibian taxonomy:

- **Al-maṣāliḥ al-ḥayawiyya — vital interests.** Uit-lirboyo The bodily, biological, material conditions of human life — what classical *maqāṣid* mostly captures under *ḥifẓ al-nafs*

and *ḥifẓ al-māl*.

- **Al-maṣāliḥ al-ʿaqliyya — rational interests.** Uit-lirboyo The conditions for the development and exercise of intellect, including knowledge, education, deliberation, free inquiry — overlapping with *ḥifẓ al-ʿaql* but expanded.
- **Al-maṣāliḥ al-rūḥiyya — spiritual interests.** Uit-lirboyo The conditions for orientation toward God, growth in virtue, the cultivation of the heart's openness to the divine — the dimension Tāhā argues is systematically attenuated in modern (utilitarian and Kantian) ethical discourse.

Tāhā grounds this reorganization in the prophetic statement *innamā buʿithtu li-utammima makārim al-akhlāq* ("I was sent only to perfect the noble qualities of character"), Substack arguing that the entire revealed law is most accurately read as an apparatus for the perfection of *akhlāq*, Uit-lirboyo with maṣāliḥ as the conditions for that perfection.

The committed reader should hold these together. Shāṭibī's hierarchy is the structural skeleton — the way the Sharīʿah's commands actually map onto the protected goods. Auda's systems approach is a methodological corrective against rigid taxonomic readings. Tāhā's three-axis reorganization is a *spiritual* corrective that prevents *maqāṣid* discourse from collapsing into the secular language of "human development indicators" or "well-being measures." The classical hierarchy without Tāhā's spiritual axis can drift into a sophisticated utilitarianism; Tāhā's axis without the classical hierarchy can drift into vague spiritualism. You need both.

3.6 The interior dimension: *niyya* and the personal *maṣlaḥa*

The hadith of *innamā al-aʿmālu bi-l-niyyāt* — "actions are only by intentions" — is also a hadith about benefit, not only about ethics. It tells you that *the same outwardly identical act may be beneficial or harmful depending on its inner direction*.

The continuation of the hadith in al-Bukhārī's narration makes this concrete:

> *وَإِنَّمَا لِكُلِّ امْرِئٍ مَا نَوَى، فَمَنْ كَانَتْ هِجْرَتُهُ إِلَى اللَّهِ وَرَسُولِهِ فَهِجْرَتُهُ إِلَى اللَّهِ وَرَسُولِهِ، وَمَنْ كَانَتْ هِجْرَتُهُ لِدُنْيَا يُصِيبُهَا أَوِ امْرَأَةٍ يَنْكِحُهَا فَهِجْرَتُهُ إِلَى مَا هَاجَرَ إِلَيْهِ.*

> "And each person shall have only what he intended; so whoever's emigration was to God and His Messenger, his emigration is to God and His Messenger; and whoever's emigration was for some worldly thing he might gain, or a woman he might marry, his emigration is to what he emigrated to."

The two *muhājirūn* in the example perform the same outward act — they pack their belongings, leave Mecca, go to Medina, undergo the same hardships. But the act is two different acts: one is *hijra* in the religious sense, an act of *ʿibāda* with eternal weight; the

other is travel in the social sense, a transaction whose return is exhausted in this world.

This generalizes. The same gift, the same kindness, the same sacrifice, the same study of philosophy, the same writing of a book, performed with two different *niyyas*, are two different acts with two different benefit profiles. The personal *maṣlaḥa* of any given action — what it actually does for the agent's standing before God — is not visible from the outside. It is a function of the *qalb* (heart) of the agent, which is precisely the locus the Qurʾān insists on: "The Day when neither wealth nor children will benefit, except him who comes to God with a sound heart" (Q. 26:88–89, *qalbin salīm*).

This means that the answer to "is this beneficial?" is incomplete without the question "with what intention?" A thoughtful Muslim asking himself whether to take a given job, marry a given person, write a given book, give a given donation, has to do the structural analysis (which tier, which protected good, what trade-offs) *and* the inner analysis (what is my *niyya*, and is it sound?).

3.7 Synthesis: a working calculus of benefit

Here is the position I am willing to defend:

Benefit is real, structured, and rankable, but it is not utility. It is whatever serves the function for which the human being was created, calibrated to a tiered structure of protected goods, and qualified by intention.

The operative hierarchy. When two putative benefits conflict, apply in order:

1. *Ḍarūriyyāt before ḥājiyyāt before taḥsīniyyāt.* A serious threat to one of the five protected goods outranks any number of refinements.

2. *Within ḍarūriyyāt, dīn is the organizing axis.* Other necessities are protected because they enable the human being to live as a *ʿabd* (servant). When the choice is between losing one's religion and losing one's life, classical jurists permit (sometimes require) the loss of life — under the specific and narrow conditions the tradition specifies.

3. *Aversion of harm before procurement of marginal good.* The classical maxim *darʾ al-mafāsid muqaddam ʿalā jalb al-maṣāliḥ* — "averting harms takes priority over securing benefits" — is a sound rule of thumb for cases of risk and uncertainty.

4. *The certain over the merely probable.* A high-probability harm is more decisive than a possible benefit of similar magnitude.

5. *Spiritual benefit (Tāhā's rūḥiyya axis) outweighs merely vital benefit at the margin.* When the choice is between a course that secures more material comfort and one that secures more orientation toward God, the latter is preferred — provided the vital floor is not breached.

The *niyya* re-qualifies everything. No external calculus can substitute for the inner test: *am I doing this for God, or for what I will get from it?* The same act, with two different *niyyas*, has two different benefit profiles before God.

The future-oriented horizon. The Muslim's calculus is not bounded by this life. An act whose worldly benefit is small but whose *ākhira*-benefit is large is, on the relevant scale, more beneficial than its worldly opposite. This is not other-worldliness in the pejorative sense; it is the recognition that the relevant time horizon for a being whose ultimate situation is eternal is not the life of the body.

Practical test for the inquirer. When you face a question of benefit, ask in order: *Which tier is this — ḍarūrī, ḥājī, or taḥsīnī? Which of the protected goods does it touch — dīn, nafs, ʿaql, nasl, māl? Vital, rational, or spiritual maṣlaḥa, and to whom — me, my family, my community, the wider human world? What harms does it risk, and how certain are they? And what is my niyya?* When you have answered honestly, you will usually know. When the answers conflict, you have a real moral problem — the kind for which careful thought, consultation with people of *ʿilm*, and prayer (*istikhāra*) are made.

IV. Synthesis across the three questions

The three questions are not independent. Their answers interlock.

Truth grounds ethics, and ethics grounds the calculus of benefit. If you do not know what is true about the human being — what he is for, where he comes from, where he is going — you cannot reason about what he ought to do. If you do not know what he ought to do, you cannot rank what is beneficial for him. The is/ought gap is closed because the "is" of the human being is not bare; it is functional. The benefit calculus is structured because the function is structured.

Reason and revelation are not rivals; they are partners with different jurisdictions. Reason perceives correspondence (the form of truth), recognizes broad moral outlines (the form of ethics), and weighs consequences (the form of benefit). Revelation specifies what reason underdetermines: which particular doctrines about the unseen are true, where the precise boundary cases of right and wrong lie, what the protected goods are and how they rank. The hostility between reason and revelation that characterizes much of post-Enlightenment thought is not a finding; it is a presupposition, and one that — as Tāhā has shown for Kant and as Jackson has shown for the orientalist reading of Ashʿarism — does not survive close inspection.

The interior is not optional. All three questions have an inner correlate. Truth has *yaqīn*, the rest of the heart in what is established. Ethics has *niyya*, the inner direction that re-qualifies the act. Benefit has *qalbin salīm*, the soundness of heart that alone makes the

calculus matter. A philosophical chapter can describe these interior dimensions; it cannot supply them. They are practices, and the only way to acquire them is to do them.

The committed reader's stance. The position of this chapter is: moderate Ashʿarism in metaethics (rejecting both naïve rationalism and crude divine command), Russellian correspondence in epistemology supplemented by classical *yaqīn*-discipline and Nursīan cumulative-case reasoning, and a Shāṭibian-Tāhāwian hierarchy of maṣlaḥa for benefit. This is not a compromise; it is a synthesis that takes the tradition as primary and uses contemporary thought (Russell, Hume, Kant, Aristotle, MacIntyre, Pigden, Auda, Jackson, Tāhā) as conversation partners that sharpen the tradition's own resources.

Recommendations

Concrete next steps for the inquirer, in roughly the order in which I would take them.

1. **Read Russell's *Problems of Philosophy* chapters XII–XIII alongside the opening of Sūrat al-Najm (53:23–30), where the Qurʾān itself articulates the *ẓann/ḥaqq* distinction.** The juxtaposition will fix the correspondence theory in your mind in a form your tradition has been articulating in its own vocabulary for fourteen centuries. *Threshold to revisit:* if you find yourself drawn to coherentism or pragmatism as a *definition* of truth, you have backslid; reread Russell.

2. **Sit with the actual is/ought passage in Hume (*Treatise* III.i.1, Selby-Bigge pp. 469–470) and MacIntyre's 1959 article side by side.** Convince yourself that the gap is real but bridgeable. *Threshold to revisit:* if you encounter someone confidently doing ethics from a purely descriptive science (evolutionary psychology, neuroscience of "moral instincts," game theory) without acknowledging that they are smuggling in a conception of human function, you should be on guard.

3. **Read Sherman Jackson's "Alchemy of Domination?" (1999) and the relevant chapters of *The Islamic Secular* (2024).** This will free you from the false choice between "Ashʿarī = irrationalist" and "Muʿtazilī = rationalist" that dominates much undergraduate-level Islamic studies. *Threshold to revisit:* if you find yourself forced to choose between a theology that says reason knows nothing and one that says reason knows everything, you have stopped reading carefully.

4. **Work through al-Shāṭibī's *al-Muwāfaqāt* volume 2 in Arabic if you can, or in Imran Ahsan Khan Nyazee's translation if you cannot.** Pair it with Auda's *Maqasid Al-Shariah as Philosophy of Islamic Law* and at least one extended piece on Tāhā ʿAbd al-Raḥmān (Hallaq's *Reforming Modernity* is the best entry in English). *Threshold to revisit:* if the *maqāṣid* framework starts to feel like a recipe — apply tier 1 here, tier 2 there — go back to Shāṭibī's actual structural argument by *istiqrāʾ*. The framework is alive; recipes are dead.

5. **Read the 23rd Word, the 30th Word (*Ene Risalesi*), and *Āyat al-Kubrā* in Vahide's translation.** Read them slowly, with notes, over months rather than weeks. Nursī is not difficult, but he is dense, and his contribution is cumulative. *Threshold to revisit:* if you find yourself quoting Nursī rather than thinking with him, slow down.

6. **Adopt the daily *yaqīn*-discipline.** When you find yourself about to claim something publicly, ask: *what is the actual epistemic status of this claim? Sense, reason, tawātur, single-source report, cumulative case, or my own desire?* Speak with the certainty your evidence warrants, not more. This single discipline, practiced for a year, will change the texture of your moral life more than reading another book.

7. **Adopt the *niyya*-check before significant actions.** Before any decision of weight — accepting a job, marrying, taking on a public role, writing a book — pause and ask: *what is my niyya here? Is it sound? If the worldly outcome were entirely different, would I still do this?* The check is not infallible — *niyya* can deceive itself — but it is corrective.

8. **For benefit-questions, train yourself to do the explicit hierarchy.** When facing a real decision, write out: *the ḍarūrī goods at stake, the ḥājī goods at stake, the taḥsīnī goods at stake; the vital, rational, and spiritual dimensions; the certain harms versus the probable benefits; the niyya.* This is not bureaucratic — it is the diagnostic tool that prevents the calculus from being captured by your own desire.

9. **Find a teacher.** None of this can be done alone. *Maqāṣid* applied without supervision drifts; *yaqīn*-discipline without correction drifts; *niyya*-check without an external mirror drifts. The Islamic tradition has always insisted on *ṣuḥba* — companionship in knowledge with someone further along the road. Find such a person.

10. **Re-examine these answers in five years.** The positions defended in this chapter are *committed* but not *infallible*. New evidence, new arguments, new experience, deeper engagement with primary texts may revise them. The right disposition is neither dogmatic adherence nor restless skepticism; it is a tested confidence that remains open to revision under conditions specified in advance — the same disposition the tradition itself has historically modeled.

Caveats

1. **This chapter takes positions; it does not prove them.** Each of the synthesis claims — moderate Ashʿarism, Russellian correspondence, the Shāṭibī-Tāhā hierarchy — is defensible, but a full defense of any one of them would require a book. The reader who is not yet persuaded has every right to demand more; this chapter is an invitation to that work, not a substitute for it.

2. **The orientalist caricature of Ashʿarism is wrong, but the caricature of the Muʿtazila**

is also wrong. The Muʿtazila were not Enlightenment rationalists; their rationalism was disciplined by an austere conception of divine justice (*ʿadl*) and divine unity (*tawḥīd*) that most modern rationalists would find uncongenial. The contrast between the two schools is real but more nuanced than the textbook account.

3. **Hume's is/ought gap is real.** Closing it via teleology requires accepting a *substantive* claim about human function — that the human being *has* a function, recognizable by reason or supplied by revelation. A strict naturalist who denies this can, with consistency, refuse the bridge. The argument with him is not over the logical point but over the descriptive premise.

4. **Kant's substantive insights are real even if his self-presentation fails.** Tāhā's critique shows that the categorical imperative cannot stand on Kant's *own* foundation; it does not show that the imperative is *false*. "Treat persons as ends, not mere means" is true and defensible from Islamic premises (*karāma* of the human being, *amāna* borne by him), and the convergence with Kant is itself a clue that the imperative captures something real.

5. **Nursī is doing phenomenology, not philosophy in the academic sense.** His arguments are sometimes proofs and sometimes invitations; he often moves by analogy where a Western philosophical text would move by deduction. This is a feature, not a bug — but it means that "Nursī's argument" must sometimes be reconstructed by the reader. A reader trained only in Anglo-analytic philosophy may need to recalibrate his expectations. The Vahide translations published by Sözler render Nursī's Ottoman Turkish more closely; the Akarsu translations published by Tughra are smoother for the contemporary English reader; the committed student should consult both.

6. **The *maqāṣid* framework is a tool, not a verdict.** Two competent jurists can apply it and reach different conclusions on the same case. The framework constrains the space of permissible answers; it does not always single out one answer. This is a feature of any genuinely substantive normative framework — including Kantianism and consequentialism — and is not a defect peculiar to Islamic legal theory.

7. **Tāhā ʿAbd al-Raḥmān's reorganization of *maṣāliḥ* into vital/rational/spiritual is contested.** His position is ambitious and not universally accepted within contemporary Islamic legal thought. It is offered here as a defensible *complement* to the Shāṭibian framework, not a replacement for it. No full English edition of his major works exists; readers without Arabic must rely on Hallaq's *Reforming Modernity* and the secondary literature.

8. **The committed reader should expect to be wrong about some things.** The tradition itself models this: Imam al-Shāfiʿī famously revised major positions when he moved from Iraq to Egypt; al-Ghazālī's intellectual trajectory from kalām through philosophy to

taṣawwuf is a model of intellectual courage. The expectation that one's current synthesis is final is the surest sign that one has stopped thinking.

9. **The interior dimensions — *yaqīn*, *niyya*, *qalbin salīm* — cannot be argued for at length here.** They are practices, not propositions. A philosophical chapter can describe them, distinguish them, and recommend them. It cannot supply them. The reader who finds himself satisfied with an *intellectual* understanding of *niyya* without ever pausing to check his own *niyya* before action has misread the chapter.

10. **The ultimate epistemic horizon is theological.** Truth (*ḥaqq*) is grounded in the Truth (*al-Ḥaqq*); ethics (*ḥusn*) is grounded in the function set by the Wise (*al-Ḥakīm*); benefit (*maṣlaḥa*) is grounded in what serves that function as known to the All-Knowing (*al-ʿAlīm*). The three questions converge on the One whose being is the source of all three answers. This is not the conclusion of an argument; it is the framework within which the argument has been conducted from the first sentence. The committed reader will know whether to find this honest or question-begging by his own response when it is named.